

1957

Fairchild And DEC

May: Fairchild is established

Fairchild Semiconductor was established in May of 1957 to develop silicon-based semiconductors. Composed of a nucleus of eight engineers (Robert Noyce and Gordon Moore, Intel's founders, were two of them), the company has many pioneering advances in transistor technology to its credit—the planar process, which made transistors cheaper to make and more reliable, op-amps, and circuits for Cray supercomputers. Fairchild is a publicly-traded company and now specialises in products for optimising system power.

June: A calculator made only of electronic circuits

Casio, a Japanese company founded in 1946, released the Model 14-A, the first all-electric compact relay calculator (which in plain language means electronic circuits!). Early calculators used gears and were operated by cranks or motors. Casio's calculator, apart from being electronic, used a ten-button keypad instead of individual keys for individual numbers and a single display pane. Casio Computers Company Ltd. was also founded, and the firm is a major manufacturer of calculators, PDAs, watches, cameras, and audio equipment.

Summer of '57: An AI problem solver

The General Problem Solver was invented by Herbert Simon and Alan Newell in the as an artificially intelligent “universal problem solver.” Theoretically, the General Problem Solver could solve any problem that could be put into a formal notation. Though it could solve some problems in computer theory like the “Towers of Hanoi,” it was unsuccessful at solving abstract real-life problems.

August: DEC is founded

Digital Equipment Corp. (DEC) was founded in August by Ken Olsen and Harlan Anderson, two engineers working on the TX-2 computer project at MIT. Its early products included electronic components like flip-flops and gates. It later on built complete